Research with AI Agents

What Works, What It Costs, and What an Institute Needs

Lukas Theissinger

October 30, 2026

Outline

OpenAI and Agent Usage

Owning Intelligence and Infrastructure at Lamarr

Staying Up to Date with AI

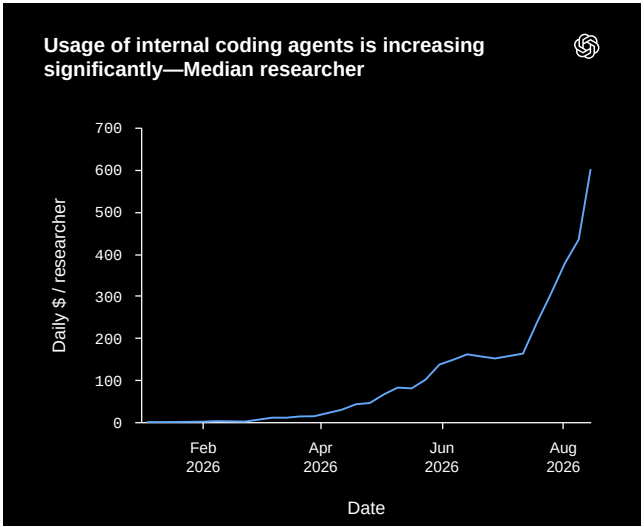
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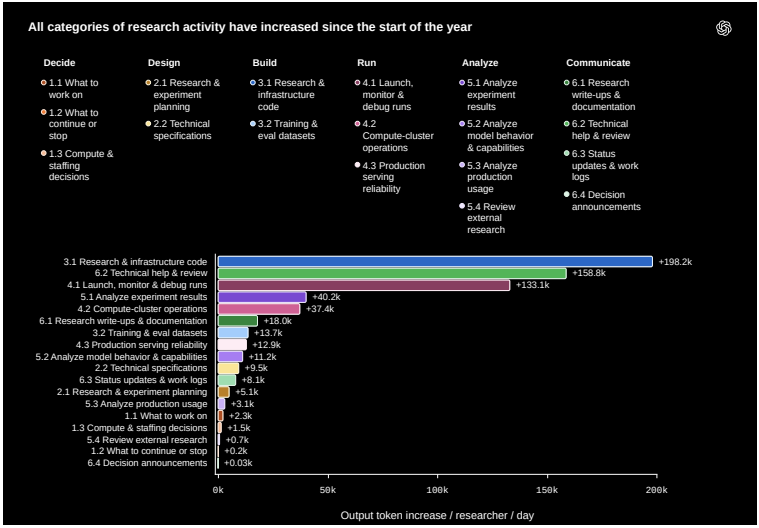
Staying Up to Date with AI

FOMO Headline: OpenAI Agent Usage



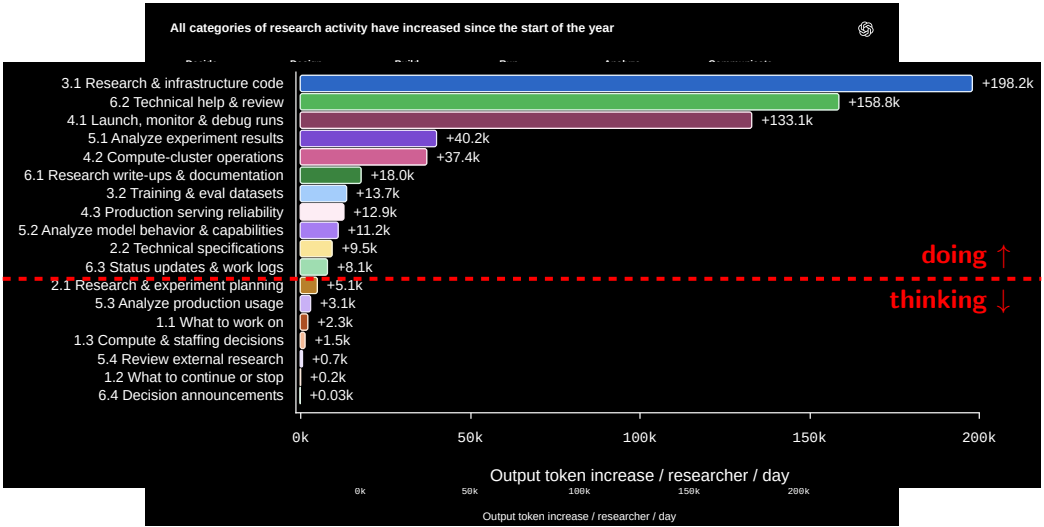
Median researcher, daily $ spent on internal coding agents. Source: OpenAI, "Research acceleration" (self-reported).

What do agents do at OpenAI?



Increase in output tokens per researcher per day, by research activity. Source: OpenAI, "Research acceleration" (self-reported).

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Tim Dettmers' hypotheses, read against the OpenAI usage data

What the OpenAI chart suggests

All 18 activities went up: agents are used everywhere, but how much and how exactly is still open.

Sources: timdettmers.com/2026/01/13/use-agents-or-be-left-behind; OpenAI, "Research acceleration" (self-reported).

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Did agents take over the *thinking*? We can't say: a plan or a decision is short, so tokens are the wrong measure.	Agent use is a *skill*: not everything can or should be automated (degree of automation).

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Field Report: Automating Exercises

1. **The problem.** PhD student, tutoring an exercise class every two weeks:
   - 2 h exercise class + 6 h preparation (solving the tasks, making the slides)
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4. **Ask your agent to try it:** `github.com/Newida/AutomatingExercises` **Avoid:** Don't do anything BY HAND on this project. If you want to change it, ASK YOUR AGENT to change it.

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Automating at Bigger Scale

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Example: travel expense reports

Collect receipts, fill in the university form, look up per-diem rules, fix what admin sends back: say **3 trips** $\times$ **3 h per person per year**. An agent that reads the receipts and files the form correctly needs $\sim$**200 h** (rules, forms, access to the admin system).

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institute, 10 000 people	$10\,000 \times 9\,\text{h} = 90\,000\,\text{h/year}$	200 h	**pays $>$400$\times$**

What It Costs

What an Institute Needs

Takeaways

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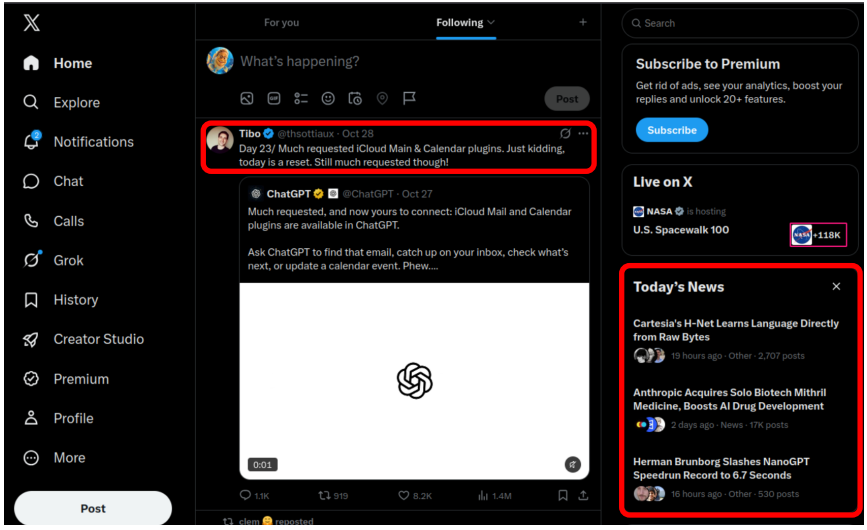
How to Stay Up to Date

1. **Make an X (Twitter) account.**
   Many people from the frontier labs post there first, often daily.

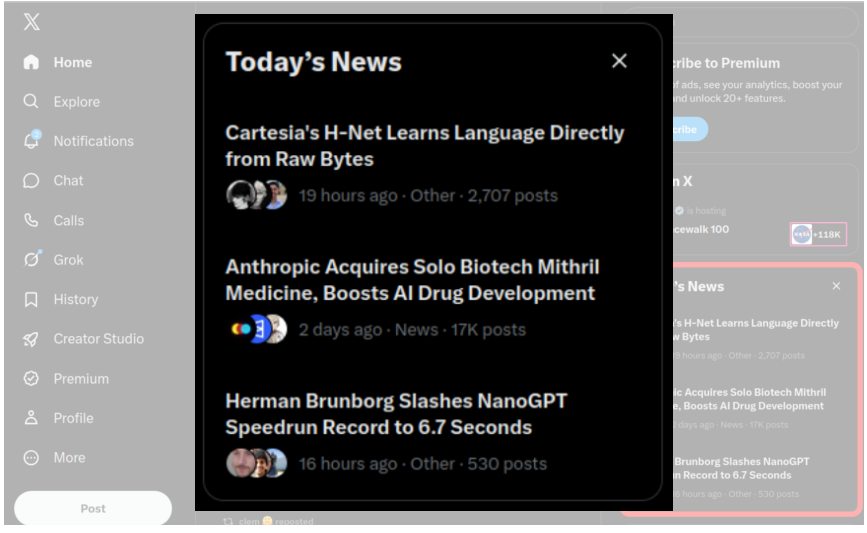
2. **Read "Today's News" on the home page.**
   It sums up the biggest updates of the day.

3. **Follow the right people.**
   Don't be fooled by clickbait.

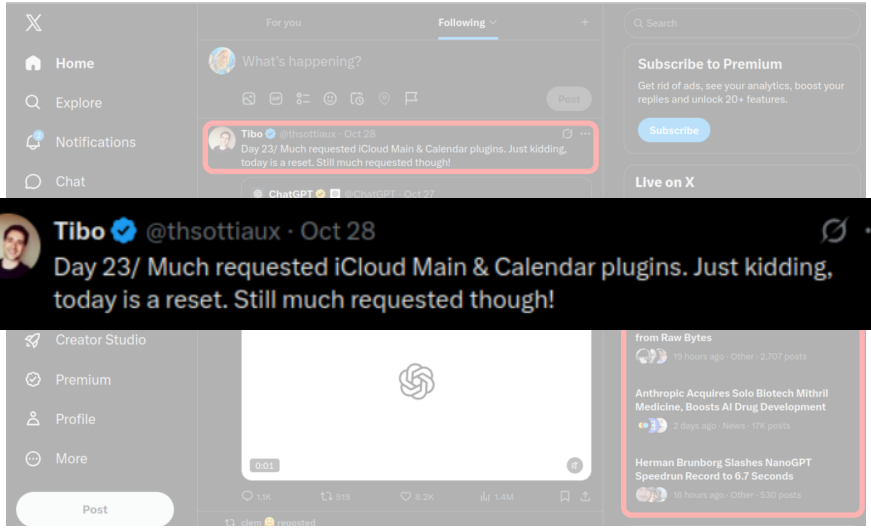
Read Today's News



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Tibo @thsottiaux · Oct 28

Day 23/ Much requested iCloud Main & Calendar plugins. Just kidding, today is a reset. Still much requested though!

Who to Follow and Why

Who	Handle	Why
Andrej Karpathy	@karpathy	Clear explanations of LLMs and how to work with them
Thibault Sottiaux (tibo)	@thsottiaux	Leads OpenAI Codex; news on Codex releases and usage limits
Boris Cherny	@bcherny	Created Claude Code; how Anthropic uses its own agents
Tim Dettmers	@Tim_Dettmers	Agents in academic research; open models on small budgets
Victor Taelin	@VictorTaelin	Tests frontier models on hard coding problems
Felix Rieseberg	@felixrieseberg	Builds Claude's desktop apps at Anthropic; early product news

A few of the 251 accounts I follow, all of this kind.

A Recent Headline You Might Have Missed



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